

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"The road has changed everything for us"

JITENDRA KUMAR, 35
Gram Pradhan, Pure Deewan village, Basti district, Uttar Pradesh

Once a muddy, impassable track, the 1.2 km PMGSY stretch connecting Pure Deewan to NH 28 at Arjunpur is now a smooth, all-weather road. Built a decade ago, it has not only transformed Pure Deewan's fortunes but has also unlocked opportunities for over 50 other villages in the region. "Earlier, vehicles would frequently get stuck. We relied on *khadanja* (brick-laid) roads, which barely lasted and became unusable during monsoons," says Jitendra. Initially narrow, the road was later widened and repaired in 2022.

"Even bicycles struggled during the rains," Jitendra recalls. Today, tractors, trucks and heavy vehicles move easily. Trucks carrying cement and other goods reach the village regularly, leading to the establishment of construction material shops and new employment opportunities. Farmers benefit greatly, transporting crops like sugarcane and wheat to markets without delays or damage.

Access to healthcare, education and markets has improved significantly. Children no longer miss school during the rainy season, and ambulances can now reach Pure Deewan promptly during emergencies.

"The road has changed everything for us," Jitendra says. ■

THE EASE OF LIVING

The launch of the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY) in 2000 marked a pivotal moment in India's rural development. Designed to connect unserved or underserved habitations with all-weather roads, the programme aimed to unlock rural India's untapped potential. Initially targeting villages with populations of 500+ in plains and 250+ in hilly areas, the PMGSY has evolved significantly over the years. Under PMGSY-I, 624,628 km of roads were constructed. By 2013, PMGSY-II shifted focus to upgrading approximately 50,000 km of existing roads. In 2019, PMGSY-III expanded its scope, consolidating nearly 90,000 km of critical links to economic and social hubs. The government has now launched PMGSY-IV, with a target of 62,500 km to be built by FY29. Sustainability is a priority, with 15 per cent of the projects incorporating green technologies such as waste plastic, cold mix and chemical stabilisation.

The results have been transformative. Of the 817,198 km sanctioned, 771,392 km of roads have been built, with an investment of Rs 3.32 lakh crore, connecting 171,107 habitations. These roads have linked countless villages to highways, improving access to healthcare, education and employment. "PMGSY has improved lives," notes a state rural development department official. "It's a catalyst for rural empowerment, enabling communities to access better livelihoods, markets and services."

Countless villages are now connected to highways, improving access to healthcare, education and employment

PMGSY's socio-economic impact is profound. Farmers can now transport produce efficiently, children attend schools regularly and medical services reach remote areas swiftly. Villages isolated previously have been linked up to vibrant hubs of activity.

Since 2013, over 66,000 km of roads have been built and upgraded using eco-friendly methods, reducing environmental impact while ensuring cost-effectiveness. The programme's achievements have attracted global recognition, setting benchmarks for large-scale rural infrastructure projects. A global conference on rural road technologies, organised in 2022 in Delhi, highlighted its forward-looking ethos.

However, despite these successes, challenges persist. Maintenance of the vast network is critical, as heavy vehicle movement accelerates wear and tear. Funding delays and uneven resource allocation in certain regions continue to hinder PMGSY's full potential. ■